

Editorial

Shut Up!

THAT'S WHAT THE Government said last month to the Indian blogging community. In a knee-jerk reaction to the Mumbai blasts, the Computer Emergency Response Team of India (CERT-IN) instructed all Internet Service Providers to ban a select 17 sites that might (as per the Government's belief) help terrorists communicate with each other. Unfortunately for the blogging community, some of these were on free blog hosting providers — TypePad and Blogspot — while some were on Geocities, a free service. As a result of the gag order, the ISPs banned the two blog domains as well as Geocities in their entirety!

Did they do this because they didn't know how to block specific sites? If that's the case then this move surely reflects the lack of understanding about IT amongst both ISPs and the Government. It also smacks of covert attempts at Internet censorship—because all this happened discreetly, without any prior notice or a public announcement.

Indian bloggers gradually discovered, to their dismay (after having exchanged notes—on the phone for a change), that access to their blogs had been blocked. Worse still, the director of CERT feigned cluelessness when asked about the drastic move. His initial response when asked about the ban: "Somebody must have blocked some sites. What is your problem?"

Knives were out immediately, and bloggers around the world united to start a site where censorship on the Net was discussed threadbare, and where details on how to circumvent the ban were given out. A majority of Indian dailies reported the incident and printed the entire list of the 17 banned sites. As a result, these very sites, which were possibly nondescript till now had been made famous thanks to the ban, and their traffic shot up. "It thrills me to death that my little online journal has been noticed by the wonderfully tolerant Government of India," said one blog carrying political propaganda.

What also happened as a result of this ban is that genuine and resourceful blogs such as mumbai-help.blogspot.com set up to disseminate vital information during emergencies in Mumbai—such as the recent blasts—were shut down. It is these blogs that come to the rescue if and when cell phone networks jam—this added to the bloggers' outrage.



Deepak Ajwani Executive Editor

"Internet might not remain the ultimate enabler of democracy"

One blogger pointedly asked, "Will the Indian Government turn off the water supply to the nation if they discover terrorists use water to live?"

This act of censorship is as futile as it is self-defeating. But it also ends up setting a dangerous precedent that any speech, online or otherwise, can be stifled if found anti-governmental.

The Government had earlier announced its intention to introduce a Broadcast Bill to muzzle the television media — apparently an attempt to arrest the series of sting operations on politicians. Then they made an amendment to the Right to Information Act that excluded, from public purview, bureaucrats' file notings. And now this Web site ban.

It suddenly seems that the Internet might not remain the ultimate enabler of democracy.

I'm appalled. These are precedents, and a possible sign of more smothering censorship to come.

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